

The PDRN Protocol” Core System Guide

The Barrier-First Skin Recovery System for the PDRN Era

Read this first (5 minutes)

You bought a PDRN serum because everyone on your feed told you it was the glow. And it might be. But here is what almost nobody selling you a \$52 ampoule will say out loud:

PDRN does not work in isolation. It works in a *window*.

That window is your **skin barrier**” the outer layer that decides what gets in, what stays out, and whether anything you apply can even reach the layer where repair happens. If your barrier is compromised, you are not applying PDRN. You are applying a \$52 peptide to a wall with holes in it.

This system exists to fix that. It is not a serum review. It is not a “10 best products” list. It is the **sequence** that makes PDRN” and every active you layer near it” actually do something.

The PDRN Protocol in one line: Repair the barrier + calm the inflammation + then and only then, feed the repair signal.

In this guide you’ll get:

1. The one-page mechanism (what PDRN actually does, and what it can’t)
2. The four-phase protocol (Reset + Rebuild + Activate + Maintain)
3. The 30-Day Calendar (which phase you’re in, day by day)
4. The “STOP Rules” five signals your barrier is begging you to pause
5. How the other 7 worksheets in this pack plug into the system

Part 1” The mechanism, in plain English

PDRN stands for *polydeoxyribonucleotide*. It is a fragment of DNA” most commonly derived from salmon, sometimes from plants like ginseng. In cosmetics it usually appears on the ingredient list as **sodium DNA** or **PDRN**.

What it is believed to do, based on the research cited by dermatologists:

- **Activate adenosine A2A receptors**” calming inflammation and supporting the skin’s own repair signaling.
- **Support new blood-vessel formation** (angiogenesis)” better delivery of oxygen and nutrients to the skin.
- **Encourage collagen renewal and tissue repair**” the same pathway the skin uses after wounding.

That is why PDRN first became famous in *clinic*: Rejuran, the Korean “healing essence,” is injected or applied after microneedling or laser” because those procedures create **delivery channels** into the deeper skin where PDRN can signal.

The blunt truth: topical PDRN without any delivery help largely sits on the surface. Topical PDRN *with* a healthy barrier, a chemical or physical delivery method, and a calm baseline is where people report the “glass skin” glow.

So the protocol has one job: **create the conditions where PDRN is not wasted.**

What PDRN is NOT

- It is **not** a plumping hydrator. If your skin feels tight and dry, hydration is a different job.
- It is **not** an exfoliant. It does not resurface. Acids do that.
- It is **not** a replacement for sunscreen. Nothing is.
- It is **not** instant. Reports of visible change cluster around **weeks 3–8**, not days 1–3.

If a product promises otherwise, that product is selling hope.

Part 2” The Barrier Audit (do this before you buy a single active)

You grade five things. Total possible: 10 points.

#	Check	Score 0	Score 1	Score 2
1	Tightness after cleansing	Tight for hours	Tight 10 min	Comfortable
2	Redness / flushing Reaction to new	Visible most days	Occasional	Rare

3	actives	Burns/stings	Mild tingle	No reaction
4	Texture (roughness, flaking)	Flaky patches	Slightly rough	Smooth
5	Stinging with water alone	Yes	Sometimes	No

Your score:

- **8â€“10 â†’ Barrier is READY.** Start Phase 3 Activate this week.
- **5â€“7 â†’ Barrier is REACTIVE.** Give Phase 1 Reset 7 days and Phase 2 Rebuild 14 days.
- **0â€“4 â†’ Barrier is COMPROMISED.** You are in Reset for at least 21 days. No actives. No PDRN yet.

Be honest. A flattering score costs you six weeks and the price of the serum you wasted.

Part 3 â€” The Four-Phase Protocol

PHASE 1 â€” RESET (7â€“21 days)

Goal: remove the insults. Stop the bleeding.

Morning: 1. Rinse with lukewarm water only (no cleanser if you can tolerate it) 2. Simple moisturizer (ceramides, no fragrance, no essential oils) 3. Mineral SPF 30+ â€” non-negotiable

Evening: 1. Gentle non-foaming cleanser, 20 seconds, lukewarm 2. Simple moisturizer â€” apply to slightly damp skin 3. Nothing else. No acids, no retinol, no vitamin C, no PDRN, no clay, no scrubs, no tools.

Rules: no hot showers on the face, no washing more than twice a day, no new products, no â€œjust oneâ€ exfoliation.

PHASE 2 â€” REBUILD (14 days)

Goal: rebuild the barrierâ€™s raw material while keeping irritation at zero.

Add, one at a time, 5 days apart: - **Ceramide + cholesterol + fatty-acid moisturizer** (the three barrier lipids) - **Panthenol (B5) or madecassoside** â€” soothing support - **Squalane or a light occlusive** at night

Still no actives. You are laying the mortar before you build the wall.

Log every product in the Product Tracker (deliverable 5). One new product at a time, 5-day gap. This is how you find your triggers instead of guessing.

PHASE 3 â€” ACTIVATE (weeks 4â€“12)

Goal: introduce PDRN and its delivery window.

Now â€” and only now â€” you introduce PDRN.

The PDRN Sandwich (the core move of this system):

1. **Cleanse** gently, pat almost dry
2. **Hydrating toner / essence** â€” a wet base layer
3. **PDRN serum** â€” 2â€“3 drops, press in, do not rub aggressively
4. **Barrier moisturizer** â€” seal it

Frequency ramp (do not skip this):

- Week 1 of Phase 3: **2 nights only** (e.g.â€” Mon + Thu)
- Week 2: **3 nights**
- Week 3: **4 nights**
- Week 4+: **5â€“6 nights**, or nightly if fully comfortable

Optional delivery boosters (choose ONE, and only after two clean weeks): - A **PDRN mask** 1â€“2â€” week (overnight masks are the most accessible entry) - **Microneedling at home:** extreme caution â€” see deliverable 7. Dermarolling yourself is the fastest way to undo everything. Prefer a professional, or skip it. - **Laser/microneedling in clinic:** this is where PDRN shines â€” but recovery downtime is part of the deal.

Keep it simple: the sandwich, the ramp, and consistency beat any stack of 12 products.

PHASE 4 â€” MAINTAIN (week 12+)

Goal: hold your result without re-injuring the barrier.

- PDRN 3–5 nights a week (your skin will tell you; 3 is plenty for most)
- One gentle acid, **1– week maximum**, only if your barrier score stays 8+
- Retinol: if you use it, put it on **separate nights** from PDRN. Never stack them.
- Re-run the Barrier Audit every 30 days.

Part 4 – The 30-Day Calendar

- Week 1 – Reset** - [] Barrier Audit (record your score: ____) - [] Strip routine to cleanse + moisturize + SPF - [] Remove acids, retinol, vitamin C, scrubs, tools - [] Start the Product Tracker
- Week 2 – Reset / early Rebuild** - [] Barrier Audit again (score: ____) - [] If score ≤ 5, add ONE barrier product (ceramides) - [] Start the Trigger Journal – note stinging, redness, tightness
- Week 3 – Rebuild** - [] Add ONE soother (B5 / madecassoside) - [] Add a night occlusive if needed - [] Barrier score should now be trending up
- Week 4 – Activate (only if score ≥ 7)** - [] Begin the PDRN Sandwich, **2 nights** - [] Do NOT add anything else this week - [] Log results in the PDRN Log (deliverable 3)
- Weeks 5–8 – Activate ramp** - [] Week 5: 3 nights · Week 6: 4 nights · Week 7: 5+ nights - [] Photograph in the same light, same time, weekly - [] Look for change around week 6 of activation, not before

Part 5 – The STOP Rules

- Pause everything (back to Phase 1) the moment any of these appear:
1. **Stinging with water alone.** Your barrier is open. Stop.
 2. **New redness that lasts more than 24 hours.** That is inflammation, not “purging.”
 3. **Flaking that itches.** Not dryness – damage.
 4. **A breakout of tiny uniform bumps.** Often a reaction, not acne.
 5. **Any product that burns on application.** Burning is not “working.”

When you pause: cleanse, moisturize, SPF, nothing else, for 7 days. Then re-run the Barrier Audit. Do not “push through.” Barrier damage compounds.

Part 6 – How this pack fits together

#	Deliverable	Use it for
1	Core System Guide (this file)	The map – read once, refer back
2	The Barrier Repair Playbook	Fixing a compromised barrier in detail
3	The PDRN Product Cheat-Sheet	What to buy, what’s worth it, what’s marketing
4	The PDRN Sandwich & Stack Planner	Exactly what goes on, in what order, what time
5	The Product Tracker	One-new-product-at-a-time discipline
6	The 30-Day Glow Calendar	Printable day-by-day checklist
7	The Treatment Stack Guide	Microneedling, laser, clinic PDRN – done safely
8	The Skin Barrier Diet & Lifestyle	The internal half nobody sells you

The honest disclaimer (read it)

This is **educational information**, not medical advice, and not a substitute for a dermatologist. PDRN research is still evolving – dermatologists themselves say “conclusions should be drawn carefully.” Nothing here diagnoses or treats a condition. If you have rosacea, eczema, psoriasis, active acne, or an impaired barrier from a medical condition, talk to a board-certified dermatologist before starting any active. Patch test everything. Pause anything that hurts.

Skin repair is slow biology, not a fast hack. The protocol works because it respects that.

The PDRN Protocol, A Barrier-first skin recovery for the PDRN era A Educational use only